DukaanDost: Complete Project Guide

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1. Overview

DukaanDost is a free web app that gives any home-based or small business in Pakistan its own online shop, order tracker and earnings summary in about two minutes, with no technical skills needed.

Working name: DukaanDost ("Shop Friend"). The name may change later; the idea stays the same.

Tagline ideas: "Your shop, your orders, your earnings, all in one link." / "Apni dukaan, apni kamai."

Hackathon domain: SME & Startup Enablement (GDG Kolachi hackathon).

In one paragraph: Thousands of bakers, tailors, boutique owners, jewellery sellers and small shopkeepers sell through WhatsApp chats and Instagram DMs. Orders get buried in conversations, prices are repeated to every customer, payments are forgotten and nobody knows what they actually earned this month. DukaanDost replaces that mess with one shareable shop link. The owner lists products once, customers order from the link, and the owner sees every order, its payment status and a simple weekly earnings summary on one dashboard. A single tap opens WhatsApp with a ready-made confirmation message, so the owner keeps the channel customers already trust.

2. The Problem

Home businesses in Pakistan run on chat apps that were never built for selling, and they lose orders, money and time because of it.

How they work today: The owner posts photos on Instagram or a WhatsApp status. Customers send a DM asking "price?". The owner types the price, again and again. The customer confirms in a voice note. The owner writes the order in a notebook, a notes app or just memory. Payment is promised later and often forgotten.

What goes wrong:

Pain point	What it looks like in real life
Lost orders	An order sits in a chat with 200 unread messages and is never fulfilled
Repeated work	The same price list is typed or forwarded to every customer, every day
Unclear payments	Nobody remembers who has paid by Easypaisa or JazzCash and who owes cash
No earnings picture	The owner cannot say how much was earned this week or which product sells best
Unprofessional image	No catalogue, no order number, no proof of purchase, so customers trust less
Existing tools are too heavy	Full e-commerce platforms need setup, a website, a domain and a monthly fee, and are rarely in Urdu

Why it matters: Home-based and micro businesses employ millions of people in Pakistan, and a large share are run by women working from home. They do not need a complicated store builder. They need something simpler than a website and more organised than a chat.

3. Target Users

DukaanDost serves two people: the shop owner who sells, and the customer who buys. The owner is the paying and deciding user, so the product is designed around them first.

Primary user: the home-based or small business owner

- Sells through WhatsApp, Instagram or Facebook
- Typical businesses: home bakers, boutique and clothing sellers, tailors, jewellery and accessories sellers, homemade food and catering, makeup and beauty services, handicrafts, small grocery and general stores
- Owns a smartphone, but may not be comfortable with websites or spreadsheets
- Often more comfortable in Urdu or Roman Urdu than in English
- Wants to look professional and stay organised without paying for a developer

Secondary user: the customer

- Already uses WhatsApp and Instagram daily
- Wants to see products and prices without asking, order quickly and know the order was received
- Often pays by cash on delivery, Easypaisa, JazzCash or bank transfer

Example personas

Persona	Business	Daily problem	What DukaanDost gives them
Ayesha, 28	Home baker in Gulshan, sells cakes via Instagram	Orders get lost in DMs and she forgets deposits	A shop link, an order list and a payment status per order
Bilal, 35	Runs a small clothing boutique page	Answers "price?" 50 times a day	A catalogue link so customers see prices without asking
Rubina, 45	Tailor working from home	Writes orders in a notebook and has no idea of monthly income	A simple dashboard with weekly earnings

4. The Solution

DukaanDost turns the chat-based selling that owners already do into a simple system: one link, one order list, one earnings view.

The core idea: Do not try to replace WhatsApp. Sit beside it. Customers keep chatting on WhatsApp, but products, orders and payments live in DukaanDost.

Design principles

- **Two-minute setup:** An owner can have a working shop link in about two minutes.
- **Zero tech skills:** Big buttons, simple words, Urdu and English.
- **Keep WhatsApp:** Customers and owners stay on the channel they trust.
- **Mobile first:** Most owners and customers use phones, so every screen is designed for a phone first.
- **Free to start:** No upfront cost, so adoption is easy.

How each pain point is solved

Pain point	DukaanDost answer
Lost orders	Every order is saved with a number, items, customer details and status
Repeated work	The shop link shows all products and prices, so the owner shares one link instead of typing
Unclear payments	Each order carries a payment status: pending, paid or cash on delivery
No earnings picture	A dashboard shows weekly earnings, order count and best seller
Unprofessional image	A clean branded storefront with logo, product photos and order confirmation
Too heavy and not in Urdu	A lightweight app with an Urdu and English toggle and no website knowledge required

5. Core Features (MVP)

The MVP has five features. Build these first and make them work flawlessly before adding anything else.

1. Shop setup

- The owner signs up with email, phone or Google
- Adds shop name, logo, short description and WhatsApp number
- Adds products with name, price, photo and optional description and stock
- Gets a shareable link such as `dukaandost.app/ayesha-bakes`

2. Customer storefront

- Opens the link on any phone, with no signup needed
- Browses products, adds items to a cart and sees the total
- Enters name, phone number and delivery address, picks a payment method and places the order
- Sees an order confirmation with an order number

3. Owner dashboard and order management

- New orders appear instantly, in real time
- Each order shows customer details, items, total and payment method
- The owner updates status: Pending, Confirmed, Paid, Delivered or Cancelled
- Orders can be filtered by status

4. Weekly earnings summary

- Total earnings this week, number of orders and average order value
- Best-selling product
- Money still pending collection

5. WhatsApp confirmation button

- One tap opens WhatsApp with a pre-filled message to the customer, for example: "Hi Sara, your order #1042 for 1 chocolate cake (Rs. 2,500) is confirmed. It will be delivered tomorrow."
- Uses a plain `wa.me` link, so no WhatsApp Business API or approval is needed

MVP at a glance

Feature	Who uses it	Effort	Demo impact
Shop setup and product listing	Owner	Medium	High
Customer storefront and cart	Customer	Medium	High
Real-time order dashboard	Owner	Medium	Very high
Weekly earnings summary	Owner	Low	High
WhatsApp confirmation link	Owner	Low	High

6. Stand-out Features

These features separate DukaanDost from a plain order form. Add them only after the MVP works end to end, in the order of the table.

Priority	Feature	What it does	Why it impresses
1	Urdu and English toggle	Whole interface switches language with one tap	Shows real understanding of local users

Priority	Feature	What it does	Why it impresses
2	Payment instructions at checkout	Shows cash on delivery, Easypaisa, JazzCash or bank details chosen by the owner	Matches how Pakistanis actually pay
3	Pending payments list	One screen listing unpaid orders with a reminder button that opens WhatsApp	Solves the "who still owes me" problem
4	Voice or photo product add	Owner snaps a photo and says the name and price, and the item is created	Makes it usable for low-tech owners
5	QR code for the shop link	Downloadable QR the owner can print or post	Helps offline and Instagram promotion
6	Simple AI help	Suggests product descriptions or replies, or summarises the week in plain Urdu	Adds a modern AI touch without risk to the core
7	Repeat customer list	Shows who orders often	First step toward loyalty features

Rule of thumb: A working MVP with two stand-out features beats an unfinished app with seven. Choose the Urdu toggle and the pending payments list first, since both are cheap to build and easy to show.

7. User Journeys

Two journeys cover the whole product. Both should work smoothly on a phone.

Owner journey: from signup to first order

1. Opens DukaanDost and signs up with Google or phone number.
2. Enters shop name, WhatsApp number and uploads a logo.
3. Adds the first products with a photo, name and price.
4. Copies the shop link or downloads the QR code.
5. Pastes the link in the Instagram bio, WhatsApp status or a chat.

6. Receives a notification when a customer places an order.
7. Opens the dashboard, confirms the order and taps the WhatsApp button to message the customer.
8. Marks the order Paid and later Delivered.
9. Checks the weekly summary to see earnings and best seller.

Customer journey: from link to confirmation

1. Taps the shop link received on WhatsApp or Instagram.
2. Browses the product catalogue and adds items to the cart.
3. Reviews the cart and total.
4. Enters name, phone number and address, and chooses a payment method.
5. Places the order and sees a confirmation with an order number.
6. Receives a WhatsApp message from the owner confirming the order.

Order status flow

Pending, then Confirmed, then Paid, then Delivered. An order can be Cancelled at any point before delivery. Cash on delivery orders move from Confirmed to Delivered and are marked Paid when the cash is collected.

8. Tech Stack, Architecture and Data Model

Use a simple, free-tier stack that a small team can build in a hackathon weekend. Use tools the team already knows if they differ from this list.

Suggested stack

Layer	Suggested choice	Why
Frontend	React or Next.js with Tailwind CSS	Fast to build, mobile friendly, large community
Database	Firebase Firestore or Supabase (Postgres)	Free tier, real-time updates for the order dashboard
Authentication	Firebase Auth or Supabase Auth (Google or phone)	No need to build login from scratch
File storage	Firebase Storage or Supabase Storage	Product photos and logos

Layer	Suggested choice	Why
Hosting	Vercel or Firebase Hosting	Free, deploys in minutes, gives a public link
WhatsApp	`wa.me` deep links	No API approval, works instantly
Language toggle	i18n library such as next-intl or react-i18next	Urdu and English, with right-to-left support
Optional AI	Claude, Gemini or OpenAI API; OCR or speech-to-text	For voice or photo product add and summaries

How the parts fit together: The owner and the customer both use the same web app in a phone browser. The app reads and writes to one database. Authentication protects the owner dashboard, while the storefront is public. Real-time database updates make new orders appear on the owner screen instantly. WhatsApp is reached only through links, so there is no server-side integration to maintain.

Data model (simplified)

Collection	Main fields
Shops	shopId, ownerId, name, slug, logoUrl, description, whatsappNumber, paymentInfo, language
Products	productId, shopId, name, price, photoUrl, description, inStock
Orders	orderId, shopId, orderNumber, customerName, customerPhone, address, items, total, paymentMethod, paymentStatus, orderStatus, createdAt
Users	userId, email, shopId

Security basics

- Only the shop owner can read orders and edit products, enforced with database security rules
- Anyone can read products and create an order for a shop
- Customer phone numbers and addresses are visible only to the shop owner
- Validate inputs on the order form to block spam

9. Business Model

DukaanDost is free to start and earns money as the owner's business grows, so adoption stays easy. All prices below are proposals to test with real owners, not validated figures.

Model	How it works	Pros	Cons
Freemium subscription	Free plan up to a limit of products or orders; paid plan unlocks more	Predictable revenue, simple to explain	Owners may resist monthly fees
Small commission	A small percentage of each order handled through the app	Owner pays only when earning	Hard to track cash orders
Premium add-ons	Paid extras such as custom domain, branding removal, analytics or automated reminders	Optional, low friction	Needs a large user base first
Partnerships	Delivery companies, payment wallets and packaging suppliers pay for access to owners	Extra income without charging owners	Needs scale and relationships

Recommended starting point: Freemium. Free for up to a small number of products and monthly orders, with a low monthly fee for unlimited use and extra features. Mention a second revenue stream such as delivery or wallet partnerships as a future option.

What to say to judges: "We start free so owners can try it in two minutes. We earn only when the owner grows, through a small monthly plan and partnerships with delivery and payment providers."

Costs to expect: Hosting and database (free tier at first), storage for photos, optional AI API usage, and the owner's time for support. Keeping the stack on free tiers keeps early costs close to zero.

10. Market and Competition

DukaanDost sits between a chat and a full online store. The gap is real, but the comparison below comes from general knowledge, so verify each competitor's current features and pricing before presenting it to judges.

Why now

- Smartphone and mobile internet use keep growing in Pakistan, and social selling on Instagram and WhatsApp is widespread.
- Easypaisa, JazzCash and bank apps have made digital payments familiar.
- Many small sellers are women working from home who want low-cost, low-risk ways to sell.

Alternatives owners use today

Alternative	Strength	Gap DukaanDost fills
WhatsApp and Instagram DMs only	Free and familiar	No order tracking, payment status or earnings view
WhatsApp Business catalogue	Shows products inside WhatsApp	No cart, no order dashboard, no earnings summary
Shopify and similar store builders	Powerful and complete	Setup effort, monthly cost, English-first, too heavy for a home baker
Marketplaces such as Daraz	Large audience	High competition, fees, and the seller does not own the customer relationship
Notebooks and spreadsheets	Free and flexible	Manual, easy to lose, no customer-facing side

Positioning: DukaanDost is not a marketplace and not a heavy store builder. It is the simplest way for a small seller to take orders and track money while staying on WhatsApp.

Defensibility ideas: Urdu-first design, local payment instructions, ease for low-tech owners, and data on small-business sales that grows with every shop.

11. Pitch and Demo Plan

The pitch should tell one clear story: a real owner, a real problem, a working fix, and a path to growth.

One-line pitch: "Thousands of home businesses in Pakistan run on WhatsApp chats and lose orders and money every day. DukaanDost gives them a shop, order tracking and earnings in two minutes, with no tech skills needed."

Suggested 5-minute structure

Time	Section	What to say or show
0:00 to 0:45	Problem	A short story of a home baker losing an order in a chat, plus one real quote from an owner you interviewed
0:45 to 1:15	Solution	DukaanDost in one sentence and the three promises: shop link, order tracking, earnings
1:15 to 3:15	Live demo	The script below
3:15 to 4:00	Business model	Free start, small paid plan, partnerships
4:00 to 4:30	Impact and market	Number of home businesses, women-led businesses, jobs supported (use sourced figures only)
4:30 to 5:00	Vision and ask	Next steps and what the team will build next

Live demo script (two phones)

1. On phone A, create a shop in under a minute: name, logo and two products.
2. Open the shop link on phone B as a customer.
3. Add items to the cart and place an order.
4. Show the order appearing instantly on phone A's dashboard.
5. Tap the WhatsApp button to open the pre-filled confirmation message.
6. Mark the order Paid and show the weekly summary updating.
7. Switch the interface to Urdu in one tap.

Tips for judges

- Interview two or three real home-business owners beforehand and quote them. It adds credibility.
- Prepare a backup: a screen recording of the demo in case Wi-Fi fails.
- Keep the demo data realistic, with real-sounding product names and Pakistani prices.
- Have one slide ready on how the product makes money.
- Practise the pitch out loud at least three times.

12. Build Plan and Team Roles

The team size and hackathon length are not yet known, so this plan is split by share of total time. Adjust the hours once the schedule is confirmed.

Phases

Phase	Share of time	Goal	Done when
1. Setup	10%	Repo, database, auth and hosting live; design basics chosen	A blank app is deployed to a public link
2. Core build	40%	Shop setup, products, storefront, cart and order placement	A customer can place an order and it is saved
3. Dashboard	20%	Real-time order list, status updates, weekly summary, WhatsApp button	The two-phone demo works end to end
4. Stand-out features	10%	Urdu toggle and pending payments list	Both features work in the demo
5. Polish and testing	10%	Fix bugs, mobile layout, realistic demo data	Three full runs of the demo with no errors
6. Pitch and rehearsal	10%	Slides, script, backup recording	Pitch rehearsed at least three times

Suggested roles for a team of three to four

Role	Responsibilities
Frontend lead	Storefront, owner dashboard, mobile layout, Urdu toggle
Backend and data	Database, authentication, security rules, real-time orders
Product and design	User flows, logo, colours, demo data, owner interviews

Role	Responsibilities
Pitch and presentation	Slides, story, demo script, business model answers

In a team of two, combine frontend with design and backend with pitch preparation.

Before the event starts

- Check the hackathon rules on whether work may begin before the event
- Interview two or three real home-business owners and note their quotes
- Agree on the stack and create accounts for Firebase or Supabase and Vercel
- Sketch the main screens on paper
- Prepare a realistic product list with photos for the demo

13. Risks and Mitigation

The biggest risk is not technical. It is scope: trying to build too much and showing a broken demo.

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Scope creep, too many features	High	High	Lock the MVP list; add stand-out features only after the demo works end to end
Demo fails on stage (Wi-Fi, bug)	Medium	High	Record a backup video; test on mobile data; keep demo data ready
Judges say "this already exists"	Medium	Medium	Stress the simplicity, Urdu-first design and WhatsApp-first flow; show the gap versus Shopify and WhatsApp catalogues
Owners will not adopt a new tool	Medium	Medium	Two-minute setup, stay on WhatsApp, free to start; quote real owners
Payments cannot be verified in-app	High	Low	Show payment instructions and a manual status; mark real payment integration as a future step
Fake or spam orders	Low	Medium	Basic form validation; owner can cancel; add phone verification later

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Privacy of customer data	Medium	Medium	Strict database rules so only the owner sees customer details
Team skill gaps	Medium	Medium	Pick tools the team already knows; use templates and free tiers
Hackathon rules ban pre-built work	Medium	High	Read the rules; do only research and planning before the event if code must be written during it

14. Future Roadmap

After the hackathon, DukaanDost can grow in three stages: make it work for real shops, make it smarter, then make it a platform.

Stage 1: Real-world pilot

- Onboard 10 to 20 real home businesses and collect feedback
- Add phone number verification and order notifications by SMS or WhatsApp
- Fix the biggest usability problems found in the pilot

Stage 2: Smarter and more connected

- Integrate Easypaisa, JazzCash and card payments so payment status is confirmed automatically
- Connect with courier and delivery partners for pickup booking and tracking
- Add inventory tracking, discount codes and customer reviews
- Offer AI features: auto-generated product descriptions, Urdu voice product entry, sales insights and reorder reminders

Stage 3: Platform

- Customer accounts and repeat-order shortcuts
- Simple credit and ledger (khata) for regular customers
- Access to small business loans or micro-financing based on sales history, through partners
- A directory where customers can discover nearby home businesses
- Support for more regional languages such as Sindhi and Punjabi

15. Hackathon Notes

DukaanDost was chosen for the GDG Kolachi hackathon under the SME & Startup Enablement domain.

Why this domain and idea

- SME & Startup Enablement is less crowded than AI, Fintech or general Software Solutions, so the project stands out.
- It needs no specialised knowledge, only a standard web app, so a small team can finish it.
- It has a clear user, a smooth live demo and a believable path to a real startup.

Other ideas considered and set aside

Idea	Domain	Why it was not chosen
TankerWatch, a map of water tanker prices and shortages	Water, Energy & Waste Management	Kept as an alternative; DukaanDost was preferred for build simplicity
Awaaz, a document reader and translator for low-literacy users	Social Impact, Accessibility & Inclusion	Rejected by the team
ScamShield, a scam message detector	Cybersecurity & Digital Safety	Rejected because the team lacks cybersecurity knowledge

Using the same idea at more than one hackathon

- The idea itself can be reused, but the code and prototype may not be, if a hackathon requires work to be built during the event.
- Check each hackathon's rules on pre-existing work, ownership of projects built at the event, and whether prior prize winners are allowed.
- Be honest if a registration form asks whether the project already existed.
- Rebuild or substantially improve the project for each event, and add new features each time.

Open items to confirm

- [ ] Read the GDG Kolachi rules: must the project be built entirely during the event?

- [ ] Confirm team size limits and the event dates and duration
- [ ] Confirm whether the domain can be changed after registration
- [ ] Decide the final product name
- [ ] Choose the tech stack the team is most comfortable with
- [ ] Interview two or three real home-business owners

16. FAQ and Glossary

Frequently asked questions

Is DukaanDost a marketplace like Daraz? No. Each owner gets their own shop link and keeps their own customers. There is no shared marketplace.

Do customers need to create an account? No. Customers open the link, add items and place an order with their name, phone and address.

How do payments work? In the MVP, the owner shows payment instructions (cash on delivery, Easypaisa, JazzCash or bank transfer) and marks orders as paid manually. Automatic payment confirmation is a future feature.

Does it need the WhatsApp Business API? No. The app uses simple `wa.me` links that open WhatsApp with a pre-filled message, so there is no approval process or cost.

Why not just use WhatsApp Business? It has a product catalogue, but no cart, order dashboard, payment status or earnings summary. DukaanDost adds those while keeping WhatsApp for conversation.

How does it make money? It is free to start, then earns through a small paid plan, optional add-ons and future partnerships.

Who is it built for? Home-based and small business owners, such as bakers, tailors, boutique sellers and small shopkeepers, who sell through chat apps.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Dukaan	Urdu word for shop
Dost	Urdu word for friend
MVP	Minimum viable product: the smallest version that works and can be demonstrated

Term	Meaning
COD	Cash on delivery
Easypaisa and JazzCash	Popular mobile wallet and payment services in Pakistan
`wa.me` link	A WhatsApp link that opens a chat with a given number and an optional ready-made message
Storefront	The public page where customers view products and place orders
Dashboard	The private page where the owner manages orders and sees earnings
Freemium	A model where the basic product is free and extra features are paid
Real-time database	A database that pushes changes to the screen instantly, with no refresh